the prison from where no one ever returned. Later, he killed Malik Muhammad and a Mīrzā.

Except for Malik Muhammad, none aspired to be the ruler but the insecure Mahmud Mīrzā continued being as brutal as he could. The second thing that disgusted people was his tyrannical acts, even though he was excellent in the administration of regulations and revenues. After reaching Samarkand on the invitation of the begs, he began to mend new regulations and implemented a new model of taxation. Both were being forced onto people. His tyranny can very well be imagined from the treatment he was giving to the dependents of Khwaja Ahrar, under whose protection poor people always lived their lives free from dues and imposts. They were being oppressed massively. As a result, the populace was not happy. Babur mentioned that oppressive extractions were made from Khwaja's every child.

His begs, retainers and followers were equally tyrannical and vicious. The Hisaris and, in particular, the followers of Khusrau Shah had turned into habitual womanizers. They picked random women from the vicinity. Once when a beg took away a man's wife, he came to Khusrau Shah seeking justice. But the response of Khusrau could have only brought more anger in the man. He said, 'She has been with you for several years, let her be with him for a few days.'

The young sons of townsmen, shopkeepers, Turks and soldiers too could not venture out from their houses for fear of being taken for catamites. The people of Samarkand after having passed around twenty-five years under the kingship of Sulṭān Ahmad Mīrzā were deeply wounded in heart and soul by this oppression and vice. The rich, destitute—all opened their mouths to curse, all lifted the hands for redress.

> *Beware the steaming up of inward wounds.*
> *For an inward wound at the last makes head;*
> *Avoid while thou canst, distress to one heart,*
> *For a single sigh will convulse a world.*
>
> —Babur[*]

The infamous tyranny of Sulṭān Mahmud Mīrzā ensured that he could not rule for more than half a year. During his reign, Sulṭān Mahmud Mīrzā had wedded his eldest son Masud Mīrzā with the second daughter of his eldest brother in the family, Sulṭān Ahmad Mīrzā. As a wedding gift, he had received gold, silver,